Three Things Families Assume About Life After a Medicaid Approval, and the Habit That Helps With Each

What each one looks like, why it's a natural thing to assume, and what to do instead.

Most families picture a Medicaid approval as the last page of the story. It's a natural thing to assume, because that's where most conversations about Medicaid stop.

Dad isn't on Medicaid and may never be, so none of these is a mistake anyone has made. They're three assumptions a family can set aside ahead of time, and the same simple habit helps with each.

1 Assuming nothing else needs to be done after approval

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Someone at the table says, “Once you're approved, that's that.” Everyone nods, and the family's picture of Medicaid ends at the word “approved.”

WHY IT HAPPENS Nearly everything a family hears about Medicaid is about getting in. But a state looks again: a renewal is the state reviewing a person's information to decide whether they still qualify, and states are required to do this through periodic renewals. [1] [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write down what you've heard about life after an approval, and who told you. Sort it into what you were told, what you're assuming and what you don't know. The last two lists are your questions for your Medicaid planner or the Medicaid agency in Dad's state.

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2 Not knowing about renewal notices, reporting requirements, or document requests until they arrive

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Dad has always done his own paperwork, and he's good at it. Nobody else knows where his statements are kept, where his mail goes, or who would open an official letter if he ever wanted a hand.

WHY IT HAPPENS There's no case, so there has never been a letter, and nobody describes the mail that follows an approval. The federal renewal flyer says a state mails a letter about a person's coverage, and that the letter says whether a form or other information is needed. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask Dad who he'd want handling the mail and the paperwork if he ever wanted help, and write the name down. Then choose one place for his records and make sure a second person knows where it is. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau suggests a safe, easily accessible location, with trusted family told where to find things. [3]

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3 Not realizing that changes in finances or circumstances could affect eligibility

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Dad mentions selling the lake cabin someday, or moving nearer to your sister. It's family news, and nobody thinks of it as something to write down.

WHY IT HAPPENS These are ordinary plans, and they're Dad's to make. In general terms, though, the nonprofit Justice in Aging notes that changes in a person's life, such as moving, retiring or a rise in income, can change their Medicaid eligibility. Which changes, and how, depends on the state and the situation. [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Keep a short list of the changes that may be coming, each with a rough date and a question beside it. Before a large one, bring the question to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money says to get legal advice about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility for Medicaid. [4]

The one habit behind all three

Write it down, and ask before acting. What you've heard, where the records are, what may be changing: each becomes a line on a page and a question for the right professional.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what Medicaid requires after an approval in any state, whether a change would matter for Dad, or what to do about money or property. It names three assumptions, the same three the Medicaid Planning Roadmap sees at this step, and a habit for each. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know the three assumptions to set aside, and the habit that takes the place of each. The planning interview gives that habit somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner or to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The statements about renewals, the state's letters and changes in circumstances come from the sources below, as do the advice about where to keep records and the advice to get legal advice first. The three assumptions are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
2. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
4. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney

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